

LIVING IN THE CITY

The rapid industrialization of Europe, North America, and parts of Asia in the 19th century had a huge impact on society and the environment.

During the Industrial Revolution, many people moved to towns and cities from the countryside in search of work. As a result, urban areas became crowded. Factories hired more workers, including women and children—who were paid much less than men—to increase production and profit. Workers often spent long hours in cramped, dirty, poorly lit factories for very little money.

THE STORY OF ELECTRICITY

1800

Italian scientist Alessandro Volta discovers that sinking two metals into acid can produce a steady electric current. This leads to his invention of the voltaic pile, the first reliable battery.

1876

Alexander Graham Bell, a Scottish-born inventor, experiments with turning sound waves into electric currents that could be sent through the wires of a telegraph—inventing the first telephone.

1879

US inventor Thomas Edison creates a long-lasting electric light bulb. It stays lit for 13½ hours.

1881

The world's first electric tram line, built by German engineer Werner von Siemens, opens in Lichterfelde near Berlin, Germany.

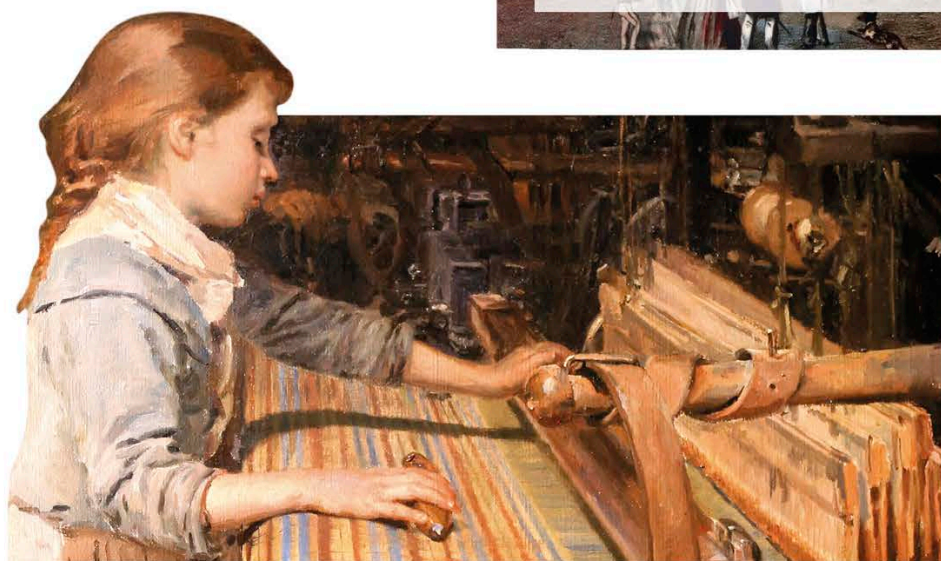
1882

Black American scientist Lewis Latimer invents a carbon filament that makes light bulbs cheaper and long-lasting.

From the mid-19th century, things began to change. Workers around the world started to organize themselves into unions to demand better pay and working conditions from factory owners. They often went on strike, which sometimes led to violent riots. At around the same time advancements in technology, improved sanitation, and the development of electric power led to improvements in city life.

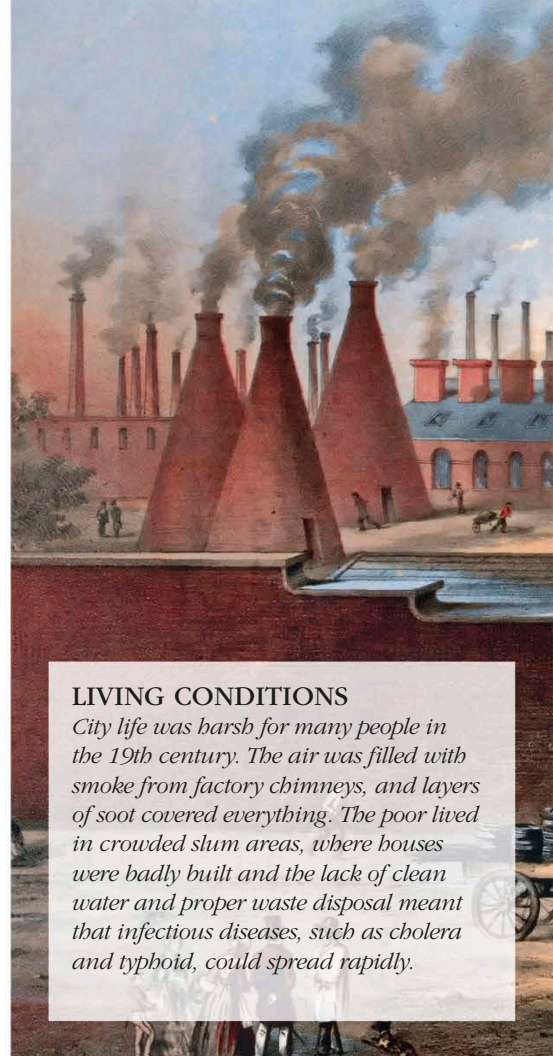
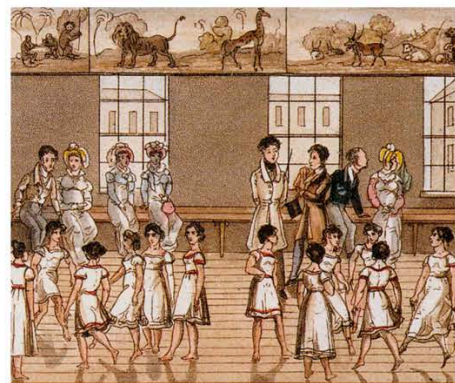
▼ CHILDREN AT WORK

During the industrial period, children were often employed by factories and mines to do jobs adults could not. For example, only children were small enough to squeeze between working looms to tie up broken threads or untangle fine threads. Conditions were often dangerous and serious injuries were common. In the 1830s, Prussia and Britain passed the first laws restricting working hours for children, and other countries soon followed.



BETTER EDUCATION ►

Most children born into poverty didn't go to school and grew up not knowing how to read or write. In New Lanark, Scotland, a textile manufacturer called Robert Owen built good-quality housing for his mill workers and set up a school (right) to provide their children with an education.



LIVING CONDITIONS

City life was harsh for many people in the 19th century. The air was filled with smoke from factory chimneys, and layers of soot covered everything. The poor lived in crowded shum areas, where houses were badly built and the lack of clean water and proper waste disposal meant that infectious diseases, such as cholera and typhoid, could spread rapidly.